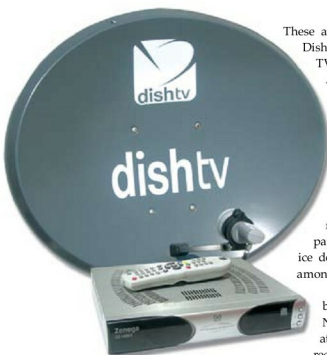




Dish TV DTH system

MPEG-4 vs MPEG-2

While both Dish TV and Tata Sky use MPEG-2 compression technology, the new DTH entrants are using MPEG-4 technology.

Through MPEG-4 technology, the DTH companies can offer more channels per transponder (a device fitted on the satellite through which DTH transmission takes place) than those using MPEG-2 technology. Under MPEG-4 compression technology, about 22-25 channels can be hosted per DTH transponder (hosted on-board the satellite) as compared to 15-17 channels that can be hosted using the MPEG-2 technology.

Although MPEG-4 will make no difference, in terms of picture quality, to customers, it makes a huge difference to the DTH service provider because MPEG-4 signals eat up far less bandwidth.

Interactive services. This is one important point where you can differentiate between broadcasters. All the broadcasters offer interactive TV services. Whether it is ordering a cooking recipe, booking tickets or watching details of a match, everything is controlled by these applications. With movie-on-demand, you can watch a movie of your choice.

Signal reception in remote areas. Another advantage of DTH is the availability of satellite broadcast in rural and semi-urban areas where cable is difficult to install.

Providers in India

In India, there are in all six DTH players fighting for the DTH TV space.

These are DD Direct, Sun Direct, Dish TV, Tata Sky, Reliance Big TV and Airtel Digital TV.

As mentioned before, one more, Videocon, will join them soon.

DD-Direct. This is government-run and broadcasts only free-to-air (FTA) channels. It is popular in remote areas and villages of India. Since most popular channels are pay channels, an FTA service doesn't have a wide appeal amongst consumers.

Sun-Direct. Promoted by Chennai-based Sun TV Network, Sun Direct operated only in South India until recently. Unique bundling of channels and effective price packaging

addition to the introductory offer, Sun Direct offers the biggest spread of 36 add-on packages ranging from Rs 6 to Rs 195 per month of the most viewed channels.

Dish TV. Dish TV was the first private DTH broadcaster in India. It started slow but picked up after the launch of Tata Sky. It offers a large bouquet of channels and is cost-effective. The provider is going to augment channel capacity to 450 from 225 at present. This is being done with an aim to boost customer base by giving depth and width of content.

Though Dish TV has a good number of subscribers, it runs on MPEG-2 and offers very few interactive applications.

Tata Sky. Compared to Dish TV, Tata Sky does offer a range of interactive applications. It has EPG in two languages: Hindi and English. The EPG is very intuitive and easy to use. The newly launched Tata Sky+ digicomp has MPEG-4 technology, a hard disk and an in-built personal video recorder (PVR). The PVR enables you to pause and rewind live TV as well as record up to 45 hours of live TV.

established it as the leader in the four southern states. In the second phase during September 2008, Sun Direct has launched its services in Gujarat, Rajasthan, HP, Punjab, Haryana and Delhi and NCR as part of the pan-India expansion programme.

Sun DTH uses the MPEG-4 technology and will launch HD services soon. It offers a basic package of over 130+ channels for an introductory offer of Rs 499 (5-month subscription) along with free dish and set-top box but Rs 1000 towards installation charges. In addition to the basic package, you can choose a regional pack of your choice for free. In



Tata Sky DTH system